ORIGINAL RESEARCH 10 JULY 2026 · REFRAMED 17 OCTOBER 2026

A DECISION, NOT A PITCH

Build for the counter. Not the marketplace.

> The operating-system model for established owner-led Nigerian and West African food businesses in one UK cluster.

DAILY TAKEAWAY	EVENT CATERING	ASSISTED SAAS

READ Decision Two cohorts Economics Boundaries Evidence 90 days So

01 — THE DECISION

UK-first assisted vertical SaaS, deliberately narrow.

Sell a practical operating system to established, owner-led Nigerian and West African takeaways and caterers in one London cluster, where they already have recurring orders and meaningful volume. Keep the two cohorts' evidence separate. The model makes the vendor the **seller, food business operator, merchant of record, payment recipient and fulfiller**; the direct-charge payment flow that does this is built and proven in Stripe test mode, with live card settlement pending the first production tenant.

Commercial starting point: £39 per location per month plus 0.5% of direct sales. A flat £79–£149 per location per month plan with no platform fee, and a £0 per month plus 6% plan for weekend and seasonal batch kitchens, are billed by the same code. Assisted setup is from £99, scoped to the work agreed; card fees pass through to the vendor's own Stripe account.

02 — TWO RHYTHMS, ONE TRUSTED OPERATOR

One kitchen, two rhythms.

THE DAILY COUNTER

Takeaway cohort

PROBLEMS TO SOLVE

- ↘ Phone, WhatsApp and walk-in orders lose context
- ↘ Kitchen handover is informal at busy peaks
- ↘ Repeat customers need a direct channel, not another marketplace fee

PILOT WORKFLOW

- ✓ Online ordering and direct customer records
- ✓ Live kitchen status and fulfilment handover
- ✓ Vendor-entered allergen information and trading-hour control

THE EVENT LEDGER

Catering cohort

PROBLEMS TO SOLVE

- ↘ Enquiries live across conversations and spreadsheets
- ↘ Deposits, headcounts and dietary requirements drift
- ↘ An event handover needs one source of truth

PILOT WORKFLOW

- ✓ Validate structured enquiry and quote capture
- ✓ Prep deposits with a balance payment link (built; Stripe test mode)
- ✓ Scheduled slots with cut-offs, a consolidated cook sheet and PPDS labels (built); validate event handover

03 — UNIT ECONOMICS / TRANSPARENT INPUTS

A model that tells you what must become true.

This is a planning calculator, not a forecast. It keeps the variable-price test honest: revenue = £39 + 0.5% of GTV; COGS = £9 + 0.1% of GTV.

MONTHLY GTV: £10,000

£0 £50k

MONTHLY CONTRIBUTION TICKET

REVENUE	COGS	CONTRIBUTION	CONTRIBUTION MARGIN
£89	£19	£70	79%

The COGS formula is a planning assumption for allocated hosting, notifications and routine support. It excludes card processing, acquisition, tax, central engineering and exceptional support.

04 — CAPABILITY TRUTH AND BOUNDARY

Be unusually clear about what the product does not do.

The credibility gain comes from giving operators a useful system without claiming an ecosystem. The first offer is SaaS and bounded assistance—not a substitute for legal, food-safety, payment or employment advice.

✓ We can support	✗ We reject

Direct ordering and kitchen coordination

Scheduled batch and catering workflows alongside the daily counter

Vendor-controlled menus and customer data

Configured onboarding within a clear cap

Marketplace and commission dependency

Owned delivery and courier fleet

J'Toye as merchant of record, or pooled funds

Full POS, free SaaS, bespoke bundles, pan-Europe and super-app scope

Payment boundary—built and proven in Stripe test mode; live cutover pending: card payments route as Stripe Connect direct charges on the vendor's own connected account, so the vendor is the seller, merchant of record and payment recipient. The vendor sets prices, controls recipes and allergen accuracy, and fulfils directly or through its own courier; J'Toye invoices software separately and holds no pooled funds in the default model. Card settlement stays in Stripe test mode until the first production tenant goes live.

Food-information and privacy boundary: distance sellers must provide allergen information before purchase and again on delivery; PPDS rules apply only to food prepacked for direct sale. Customer allergy requirements may reveal health information, so collection needs an appropriate Article 9 condition, clear notice, restricted access and short retention.

Do not claim: production or enterprise readiness; guaranteed food-safety, Natasha's Law or GDPR compliance; HMRC accounting; live card settlement or payouts before the first production tenant (built and proven in Stripe test mode only); wallets or escrow; offline KDS or ticket printing; general AI WhatsApp commerce; proven disaster recovery; self-service tenancy; or pan-European support.

05 — EVIDENCE LEDGER

What we know, what we infer, what we must earn.

Confidence labels distinguish external constraints from commercial hypotheses. Filter them before making a claim.

High

The first cluster should be narrow, not pan-European

Start UK-first with established owner-led Nigerian and West African takeaways and caterers in one serviceable cluster. Shared menus, allergen-information requests, events and repeat customers make a useful vertical wedge.

High

Takeaway and catering are two rhythms of one kitchen

Takeaways need a reliable daily order and kitchen flow; caterers and weekend-batch kitchens need scheduled slots with cut-offs, prep deposits and a consolidated cook sheet. One kitchen, one menu and one ledger run both, with the two rhythms' results kept distinct so conversion, order value and retention can be read for each.

Working assumption

£39 core can be the uncomplicated entry point

A monthly core price is legible to established operators. The billing code bills three plans: £39 per location per month plus 0.5% of direct sales (the primary plan), a flat £79–£149 per location per month with no platform fee, and £0 per month plus 6% of direct sales for weekend and seasonal batch kitchens. Assisted setup is from £99, scoped to the work agreed.

To validate

Assisted onboarding may beat a self-serve funnel

Menus, opening hours, dietary information and customer migration take care. Validate whether the setup fee pays for a repeatable, bounded onboarding service rather than bespoke consulting.

ALTERNATIVE MODEL COMPARISON

MODEL	DECISION	WHY

MODEL	DECISION	WHY
Assisted vertical SaaS	**Recommended**	Vendor retains the commercial relationship; J'Toye provides the operating system.
Marketplace	**Reject**	Would compete for the vendor's customer relationship and pull the model towards commission dependency.
Owned delivery	**Reject**	Introduces fleet utilisation, insurance and service-quality exposure outside the operating-system thesis.
J'Toye as merchant of record / pooled funds	**Reject**	Adds payment, safeguarding and settlement obligations that are not needed to create the initial value.
Full POS or super-app	**Reject**	Broadens the product before the recurring order, catering and kitchen workflows have earned expansion.

06 — 90-DAY VALIDATION BOARD

Run a small test that can say no.

Recruit 30–40 qualified prospects and accept 10–12 paid pilots split across takeaway and catering. Continue only on measured behaviour—not enthusiasm.

ACTIVATION

At least 70% go live

Gate: At least 70% of paid pilots go live (7/10, 8/11 or 9/12), then at least 70% of live pilots activate menu, the agreed payment arrangement and a first real order; median assisted onboarding is no more than four hours.

Stop criterion: Stop if fewer than 5 of 30 qualified prospects pay or onboarding repeatedly becomes bespoke.

RETENTION

At least 80% stay paid

Gate: Steady support stays below 30 minutes per merchant each month and merchants evidence saved time, fewer errors, recovered deposits, lower waste or retained direct orders.

Stop criterion: Pivot if 90-day retention falls below 70%, support exceeds one hour, or use ends after setup and labels.

ECONOMICS

Contribution reaches £75+

Gate: CAC has a credible route below £375 with five-month payback.

Stop criterion: Reprice or stop if median direct sales remain below £8,000, merchants reject a higher fixed fee, or no economic outcome is demonstrated.

07 — SOURCES AND CAVEATS

Read the boundary before quoting the guide.

This guide is a dated strategic recommendation, not legal advice or market-size proof. Local operator interviews are intentionally a validation gate, not presented as completed evidence.

ONS — Census 2021 ethnicity evidence

Food Standards Agency — allergen guidance

FCA — payment services and electronic money

UK Finance — Payment Markets 2025

ECB — SPACE 2024 payment study

Jumia Food closure evidence

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